Was Akbar surprised, maybe even a little embarrassed by their pleas? From the way Abul Fazl tells it, Akbar was no stranger to miracles, but Abul Fazl's portrait of the emperor as born to near-divine fate and fortune was far in the future still – it would be another fifteen years before he began to write the *Akbarnama*. Had Hamida told her son he made her skin glow so bright it blinded her brother, Muazzam?

When Akbar's commander Saif Khan died in the battle against Muhammad Husain Mirza outside Ahmedabad, did his mother tell the grieving emperor how he had brought about the life now sacrificed in his service? The story goes that Saif's father, desiring sons and begetting daughters, had threatened to divorce his wife if she had another girl. The poor woman was walking through the Kabul citadel to ask Hamida's permission to abort the child in her belly, when she came across Akbar, a toddler then. The prince divined her sadness, it seems, and prophesied a son. And lo, Saif was born.

Were these stories commonly told, intimate anecdotes remembered and recounted at family gatherings – or were they the result of Abul Fazl's trawling through the suggestible memories of fond relatives and retainers? Even if Akbar – like boys across cultures and times – had grown up with an idea, howsoever faint, of himself as divinely ordained, the 'miracles' of his childhood were really blessings. The many visions of light before he was born, the unexpected (and verbose) pronouncements from his infant tongue, the toddler's prophecy were all gifts from God, much like the happy shortage of just kings in Akbar's neighbourhood.

This was different: the farmers that stood before him were asking him to intervene with heaven, to demand God's favours, to act beyond the bounds of normal human agency. Akbar hesitated.

Why should he force his prayers upon God? It was hardly appropriate, or necessary, to explain to the All-Knowing what His devotees needed. Abul Fazl bolsters the point with a line of verse: 'Wilt thou teach God the path of mercy?' Perhaps Akbar was a little appalled.

Akbar was still talking when it began to rain. It rained for a week, the farmers' 'fields . . . became verdant', and their emperor . . . if he had not thought so yet, did he think so now? Who, in his place, would not have wondered whether the shahinshah of Gujarat and Bengal and everything in between, the harbinger of sons, of light, of rain, was gifted with a special